Goa First is not the lone hurdle to such happiness: talk is that a group of Congress office-bearers may join a new party named 'Goa Congress'—this time, a phonetic resemblance that's likelier to lead to sorrowful effects, sowing "confusion" among even loyal voters.

AAP has two MLAs, and the GFP's sole face in the 40-member house is president Sardesai. The ruling BJP has 28 seats (NDA 31) and the Congress has three. If it stays triangular, AAP-GFP may dent the Congress in the crucial Salcette taluka in south Goa,

Takeaways

- **AAP joins hands with regionalist Goa Forward Party of Vijai Sardesai**
- **'Goa First' tieup likely to fragment Oppn votes, BJP eyes spinoff benefit**
- **Cong-RGP alliance pins hopes on public mood, but rebellion is brewing**



'GOA FIRST' AAP leaders Arvind Kejriwal and Atishi with other Goa political leaders in Panaji, Sept. 13

IANS

which has eight seats, with about 36 per cent Catholics and 10 per cent Muslims. In such a scenario, the Congress hopes to defray its losses via a nearly-sealed alliance with the nativist Revolutionary Goans Party (RGP), whose support among the youth has drawn AAP leaders like Amit Palekar and Pratima Coutinho into its fold.

MUTUAL RECRIMINATION

The AAP-GFP duo accuse the Grand Old Party of being unworthy of an alliance due to basic infirmity—it has seen 18 MLAs defect to the BJP since 2019. The Congress, in turn, points out that Sardesai himself has been part of a BJP government as a minister and deputy CM, and that Goa First is thus in no position to issue lectures. Anyway, the sight of its rivals being consumed by recrimination helps them, admit BJP leaders. The Pramod Sawant government otherwise faces an uphill task in securing a fourth term for the BJP. That unprecedented feat may yet be eked out of Goa's small constituencies, with their razor-thin margins. A split Opposition, then, is its perfect Goan recipe to tide over anti-incumbency, a simmering fratricidal battle, and public anger over linear projects and a marauding realty sector that receives state plenitude in the form of land-use conversion.

Also, as a veteran concedes, this will be the BJP's first election without the Manohar Parrikar factor: the former CM passed on in 2019, but his warm afterglow illumined the 2022 victory, while the Opposition's light died in prismatic flickers. Now it has reason to hope for a repeat. "The GFP's alliance with AAP may eat into some anti-incumbency votes in areas like Salcette," he says.

The simmering rebellion in the Congress, with a soundalike party in the offing, does that cause no harm. "The Congress has been unable to convince people that their MLAs won't defect," says analyst Raju Nayak. Former state unit chief Amit Patkar is said to be upset after being replaced with Girish Chodankar, and has kept away from party meetings. Chodankar is brazening it out, hinting that it's "BJP sleeper cells" that are poised to go. The third front, too, was "brought in by the BJP" to fragment the field, he tells INDIA TODAY.

UNITED IN COMPETITION

A GFP leader blames the Congress for dragging its feet on an alliance and even a proposal from Sardesai for a merger. The Congress top brass avoided meeting him during their visit to Goa, he claims. The Congress wariness of a party that aims to be a big local player is real—so is its desire to peg it down. Having settled for distance, seniors rationalise it by saying the damage will be greater for the GFP and Sardesai, especially in Fatorda, his seat now for three terms. The Congress is planning to put up a stiff fight here, targeting a significant Christian and Muslim base. BJP state chief Damodar 'Damu' Naik, a former MLA here, is also eager to contest. As for AAP, the Congress makes light of Arvind Kejriwal's grand design saying it won just one of the 42 seats it contested in last December's zilla panchayat elections.

Academician Yugank Naik endorses that, saying AAP-GFP don't have a "substantial stake" in Goa. "The Congress-RGP alliance is a force that needs to be taken seriously. In 2022, the BJP came second in nine seats—in four of those, the votes pulled by RGP were more than the victory margin," he says. Despite recent churn in the party, which saw the exit of its president Manoj Parab, the RGP has a presence in the bahujan samaj. The Congress is hoping the RGP transfers at least 60 per cent of the 9.81 per cent votes it cornered in 2022, says Naik. Others are dismayed by precisely such fractional play. ■